

Dogs' Brains Can Read Some Human Emotions

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Dogs may tell some human feelings apart by looking at faces. Scientists trained 14 family dogs to lie still in an **MRI** scanner that watches brain activity.

Laura Cuaya's team at the **University of Vienna** showed the dogs photos of faces. Happy faces lit up a reward area in the brain more than neutral faces. Angry or sad faces caused different brain patterns than fearful faces.

The results were shared in the journal **iScience**. Cuaya says this is the first evidence dogs can tell different negative emotions apart on faces.

The study used **border collies** and **golden retrievers**, so other breeds might differ. Still, it is another reason to smile at a dog you meet.

Word Treasure

MRI -- A scanner that watches activity inside the brain.

University of Vienna -- The university where Laura Cuaya's team works.

iScience -- The journal that shared the dog-brain results.

border collies -- One dog breed used in the study.

golden retrievers -- Another dog breed used in the study.

Background you need

Dogs pay close attention to human faces and voices.

Brain scanners can show which areas become active during a task.

Scientists compare responses to different faces to learn what dogs notice.

Break it down

WHO: Laura Cuaya's team and 14 family dogs

WHAT: Brain scans while dogs looked at human faces

WHERE: University of Vienna research using an MRI scanner

WHY: To learn whether dogs can tell emotions apart

Why it matters

Understanding dog feelings helps kids treat pets with more care and respect.

Test what you remember

1. How many family dogs were trained for the study?

- ☐ (A) 2
- ☐ (B) 14
- ☐ (C) 100
- ☐ (D) 1,500

2. What machine watched brain activity?

- ☐ (A) A weather balloon
- ☐ (B) A bicycle
- ☐ (C) A harp
- ☐ (D) An MRI scanner

3. What happened with happy faces?

- ☐ (A) Nothing changed
- ☐ (B) They lit up a reward area more than neutral faces
- ☐ (C) Dogs flew away
- ☐ (D) Only cats responded

4. Which journal shared the results?

- ☐ (A) A sports page
- ☐ (B) A comic book
- ☐ (C) iScience
- ☐ (D) A cookbook

5. Who led the team named in the article?

- ☐ (A) Jessica Meir
- ☐ (B) Cora Walsh
- ☐ (C) Daniel Abram
- ☐ (D) Laura Cuaya

6. Which breeds did the study use?

- ☐ (A) Only goldfish
- ☐ (B) Border collies and golden retrievers
- ☐ (C) Only cats
- ☐ (D) Only wolves

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: B 4: C 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Laura Cuaya: Says this is early evidence dogs can tell different negative face emotions apart.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):